

The END

How the feared LTTE chief lost the war, his life and the hope for an independent Tamil nation and what the country has to do to win the peace

| By Raj Chengappa in Colombo |

In the northern coastal town of Velvettithurai, where Vellupillai Prabhakaran was born, there is a Tamil saying that in the face of a ferocious storm, the palmyra tree, unlike a reed, doesn't bend but breaks. This is an aphorism that Prabhakaran's supporters use to explain why one of the world's most ruthless guerrilla leaders decided to die fighting to the bitter end along with his trusted lieutenants instead of trying to get away.

It was an inglorious end for a man who was chief of a rebel army, the Liberation Tigers of Tamil Eelam (LTTE), which just three years ago controlled a third of Sri Lankan territory, bestowing on him a cult-like status among his followers, who had for more than quarter of a century carried out one of the most successful insurgent movements to secure Tamil emancipation and who had patented the macabre art of suicide bombings to mercilessly eliminate his foes and strike terror among his opponents.

His death and the total defeat of his army shattered any hope of establishing an independent Eelam and left a million Tamils homeless and vulnerable.

The decimation of the LTTE army also gave the Sinhala majority their greatest military triumph since the island's Independence in 1948. As spontaneous celebrations broke out in Colombo, an emotional President Mahinda Rajapakse, the architect of the military offensive, told Parliament on May 20, "For almost three decades the laws enacted by this legislature were not in force in one-third of our land. From now on it is only the laws enacted by this sovereign Parliament that will be in force in every inch in Sri Lanka. Our motherland has now been completely freed from the clutches of terrorism."

Yet even as the President spoke, there was no definite confirmation from the troops in the North that the Tiger chief had in fact been killed. The

